

are crashing or business applications are running more slowly.

Some spyware binds itself to key operating system files and modifies critical registry entries. Attempts to delete these files can limit or even disable the system's Internet connection capabilities. For example, WebHancer is a spyware program that automatically launches at Windows startup. It monitors Web sites being viewed and sends performance data back to WebHancer's servers. WebHancer has had conflicts with Microsoft IIS, causing problems with ASP scripts. It causes server script ASP pages to stop functioning when the Web application settings are in medium and high isolation modes. WebHancer has modified the computer's Windows Sockets configuration, binding itself to Winsock so that all packets are passed through WebHancer. Deleting WebHancer files may result in loss of ability to connect to the Internet. Employees who consider themselves sophisticated computer users may try to locate and delete spyware programs themselves, inadvertently creating even greater problems, such as the WebHancer problem described above.

Since spyware and adware are piggyback programs that run separately from the program they accompany, they use additional processing power, hard drive space, and network bandwidth. Spyware uses computer memory resources and consumes bandwidth as it sends information back to the spyware's home base via the user's Internet connection. Because spyware uses memory and system resources, the applications running in the background can lead to system crashes or general system instability. These files also consume a great deal of bandwidth and can create bottlenecks for critical business applications.

Having to close pop-up advertising windows and reset home pages that have been redirected by spyware is annoying and time consuming. Employee productivity is also affected by slow network performance and system instability. Many times, employees-unaware of the cause of their computer problems-contact the Help Desk frequently for support. This can seriously affect employee productivity and places an increased burden on Help Desk staff.